

## Eating smarter doesn't mean getting fitter



**75%** failed the pulse-above-72 test in 2009. In 2004, the corresponding figure was 62%.



**74%** failed the test of holding one's breath for 60 seconds in 2009, compared to 27% in 2004



**69%** failed the muscle strength test in 2009, an increase of 11% over a span of five years



**70%** failed to bend forward and touch their toes in 2009. In 2004, just 51% failed the same test.

people between 2000 and 2008 across eight cities—is now out. It provides a wide-ranging snapshot of public health and well-being in urban India—a baseline against which one can compare individual scores. “Numbers help in preventive care,” says Professor Adrian Kennedy, who heads the HLU. “They help doctors determine treatment and lifestyle changes to prevent serious future medical events. The same rationale works behind tracking the numbers for a wider population.”

First, the good news: the report shows an underlying trend toward improving life and “compression of morbidity”—a favoured concept in healthcare today. Evolved by James Fries of Stanford University, US, the theory holds that with improvements in lifestyle and healthcare, a nation can start living longer and better (not just longer with more sickness and disability). The health profile of urban India

shows an underlying trend toward improving life and health.

Here's a harvest of some of the most significant, heartening (sometimes baffling) statistics. We hope they will help you—in ways big and small—to understand your health issues a little bit more:

Urban Indians are getting slimmer. Excess body fat ratio compared to muscle mass has come down by 11 per cent in the last 10 years. The results support the findings of a February 2009 AC Nielsen survey which shows how urban Indians obsess over bodyweight, real or perceived (54 per cent have issues with weight, real or perceived; 48 per cent are trying to lose weight; 79 per cent plan to exercise more; 69 per cent are perennial dieters).

No wonder, eating habits have improved: 15 per cent more seem to be aware of the effects of food on the body; mindless snacking is down by 9 per cent, fat intake by 10

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